



NEW ZEALAND • OTBNZ

Registration for occupational therapists

*The Occupational Therapy Board route, and
the checklist that goes with it.*

Ethicare Resourcing

Guide and checklist • October 2026

ethicareresourcing.com

What's inside

01 Registering with the Occupational Therapy Board

This guide is free, and so is everything in it. Every chapter here is also on the website, where it is kept up to date — so if you are reading this some months after downloading it, check the site for anything that looks time-sensitive. Fees, tax rates and immigration settings change without much notice.

We don't print these. A PDF costs nothing to send and nothing to ship, which felt like the right answer for a company that spends its days moving people around the world.

Registering with the Occupational Therapy Board

For internationally qualified occupational therapists: the abridged and standard pathways, the written competence self-assessment that most applicants underestimate, the referee rules, and what the Recertification Programme means for your first year – with the checklist built into the page.



Regulator

Occupational Therapy Board of New Zealand – Te Poari Whakaora Ngangahau o Aotearoa – under the Health Practitioners Competence Assurance Act 2003

Source

The Board's published requirements at otboard.org.nz. Where this page and the Board differ, the Board is right.

Status

Checked 3 October 2026 against otboard.org.nz – the overseas qualified and abridged pathway pages, the English language policy, the recertification programme and the scope of practice. Fees and timings are not printed here because the Board revises them.

Fees & timings

Deliberately not printed. The Board publishes both and changes them; check its fees page before you budget.

AT A GLANCE

An individual assessment, not a fixed checklist

Board-appointed occupational therapists assess each overseas application on its merits. The quality of your evidence shapes the outcome.

Two pathways, plus Trans-Tasman

Abridged if you qualified and are registered in the UK, Ireland, Canada or South Africa; standard for everyone else; Ahpra registrants transfer under Trans-Tasman recognition.

On the standard pathway, the self-assessment is the centrepiece

A written desktop assessment against the Board's competencies. Specific examples from your practice; general statements rarely satisfy. The abridged pathway does not list one – check which applies to you.

Everyone new to New Zealand practice recertifies

Fortnightly supervision and Te Rito in your first period of practice. Support, not a mark against you.

What's inside

Read it once to understand the shape of the journey, then come back to each section as you reach it. The checklist at the end remembers what you have ticked, on this device.

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SECTION 01

Understanding the Board

The Occupational Therapy Board of New Zealand registers and oversees occupational therapists under the Health Practitioners Competence Assurance Act 2003. Its purpose is to protect the public by ensuring everyone practising as an occupational therapist is qualified, competent and of good character.

The title “occupational therapist” is protected by law. You cannot use the title or practise – including by telehealth from overseas – without registration and a current practising certificate. Practising, or claiming the title, while unregistered is an offence under section 7 of the Act.

An individual assessment

The single most important thing to understand about OTBNZ: overseas applications are assessed on their individual merits – fitness, equivalence of qualifications and competence – by Board-appointed occupational therapists. The quality and completeness of the evidence you provide directly shapes the outcome.

Registration and the practising certificate

Registration confirms you have met the standard. The practising certificate is what permits you to work, renewed each year; the APC year runs 1 April to 31 March. You must hold a current practising certificate at all times while practising, even under a different job title or in a voluntary role.

Qualification and competence assessment → Registration – general scope → Practising certificate → Practise in New Zealand

SECTION 02

Two pathways, and Trans-Tasman

Which pathway you use depends on where you trained and where you are registered. For many UK-based candidates the abridged pathway is the relevant one – understand it early.

Abridged

Qualified and registered in the UK, Ireland, Canada or South Africa

Your qualification must be from an education facility accredited by the World Federation of Occupational Therapists (WFOT), and you must be currently registered in that country. The evidence required is streamlined – certificate and transcript rather than the full syllabus – but the standard is not lowered, and the cultural-competence and good-character requirements still apply.

Standard overseas

Trained anywhere else

The core requirements are the same, with closer scrutiny of your course content so the Board can judge equivalence: qualification certificate, full academic transcript, and a detailed course description or syllabus.

Trans-Tasman

Currently registered with Ahpra in Australia

You register under the Trans-Tasman Mutual Recognition Act 1997 rather than the overseas-trained route – a different and generally faster process. Trans-Tasman registrants are not required to complete the Recertification Programme.

Not sure which applies?

Choosing the right pathway from the outset avoids rework and makes document-gathering far simpler. [It is one of the first things we confirm with you.](#)

SECTION 03

How the Board assesses your qualifications

Because each application is assessed individually, it helps to know exactly what the appointed assessors are looking for.

A relevant occupational therapy qualification, assessed as equivalent to a New Zealand qualification by Board-appointed occupational therapists

On the abridged pathway, a qualification from a WFOT-accredited programme and current registration in that country

Evidence of your current registration and good standing with the authority where you trained and practise

That you are of good character and a fit person to practise – confirmed through references and a criminal-history check

That you can communicate effectively in English – Section 07

Primary source verification.

The Board may require your identity and qualifications to be confirmed directly with the issuing institution, at your own cost, after your application is assessed. Build the possibility into your timeline.

SECTION 04

Demonstrating your competence

Beyond your qualifications, OTBNZ asks overseas applicants to actively demonstrate competence against its national standards. This is the part international applicants most often underestimate.

You must show you can meet the Board's *Competencies for Registration and Continuing Practice*. On the **standard pathway** this happens through three connected steps in your applicant portal, after your initial application – and your file is not processed until they are in. The Board's **abridged** page does not list a self-assessment and instructs applicants to upload a blank page in the cultural competence area instead, so confirm which pathway you are on before you start writing.

1

The written desktop competence self-assessment

The centrepiece. Against each competency you evidence how your practice meets the New Zealand standard. Vague, general statements rarely satisfy the assessors; specific examples from your practice carry far more weight.

2

Your current CV

Work history in full, with any significant gap – travel, family leave – briefly explained. [Build your CV](#) is written for this.

The Ngā Paerewa Te Tiriti eLearning course

The Board's cultural-competence requirement — Section 08.

On the standard pathway, at least one referee — an occupational therapist who has worked with you — is asked to view your self-assessment and confirm it accurately represents your practice. Choose that referee with care.

Draft your self-assessment early.

Map your experience to the New Zealand competencies before you submit, using the Board's published competencies document. Arriving at the portal with your examples already drafted turns the most demanding step into a straightforward one.

— SECTION 05

Eligibility and documents

Each document exists for a reason — understanding why makes it easier to satisfy. Clean colour scans, certified correctly the first time, consistently named: a well-organised application is assessed more smoothly than a disorganised one containing exactly the same facts.

Qualification evidence

Why

Your degree is the foundation of registration, and the Board makes its own assessment of it.

Provide

Certified copies of your occupational therapy qualification certificate and academic transcript; on the standard pathway, also a detailed course description or syllabus.

Identity

Why

To confirm who you are and link your records.

Provide

Two forms of identity documentation, one with a photograph, certified, plus evidence of any name change. Non-English documents need a certified translation alongside a certified copy of the original.

Previous registration

Why

To confirm you are registered and in good standing where you practise.

Provide

A certificate of good standing from every authority you are currently or were previously registered with, plus details of any disciplinary action taken or pending.

Hard copies still matter.

Your certified ID, qualification certificate, transcript, certificates of good standing and criminal-history check must also be sent to the Board in hard copy by post or courier, not only uploaded. Plan the postage time into your schedule.

— SECTION 06

References and criminal history

Two requirements with precise rules that are easy to get slightly wrong – and a small error means starting that piece again.

References

Three referees

Each over 18, known you for more than twelve months, not a relative, not living at your address, and a person of good standing in the community. **At least one must be an occupational therapist with whom you have worked for more than six months in the last two years.** On the standard pathway, that referee also reviews your competence self-assessment and confirms it reflects your practice.

Criminal history

Declare, and provide checks

Declare any convictions, and provide a criminal-conviction check for your country of current registration and any other country you have lived in for more than six months in the last ten years. A New Zealand check is arranged for you during processing, unless you have never been to New Zealand.

A conviction is not an automatic bar.

The Board considers each case individually. Full, honest disclosure with an explanatory note is the right approach; non-disclosure is treated far more seriously than most underlying matters.

SECTION 07

English language requirements

Safe, precise communication with clients and colleagues. The Board's rule here is specific.

When a test is needed

If English is not your first language

You are generally exempt if you completed your occupational therapy qualification, and the relevant schooling, taught and assessed in English in a recognised country – New Zealand, Australia, Canada, Ireland, South Africa or the UK. Speakers of te reo Māori or New Zealand Sign Language as a first language are exempt.

Test

OET, occupational therapy version

At the time this guide was written: a minimum grade B in each of the four components.

Test

IELTS Academic

At the time this guide was written: at least 7.0 in each band.

Clubbing is allowed, within limits.

You may combine results across more than one sitting, provided the standard is achieved within twelve months of your first test. Results must be no older than twenty-four months when submitted. If you narrowly miss on one component, clubbing may still get you there – mind both windows. Check the

Board's current English policy for the live thresholds.

SECTION 08

Cultural competence and the Recertification Programme

Two areas unique to practising in New Zealand. Understanding them early turns potential worries into straightforward, even rewarding, steps.

Ngā Paerewa Te Tiriti

Practice in Aotearoa New Zealand reflects the world views of both partners to te Tiriti o Waitangi. All applicants complete the Board's Ngā Paerewa Te Tiriti eLearning course, accessed via Ko Awatea LEARN. You request your account once the Board has confirmed your application number has been updated to your registration number – so this one, unlike the physiotherapy courses, waits for the Board's cue. Engaging with te Tiriti and Māori health early is still worth doing in its own right.

ANTICIPATE THIS

Everyone new to practice in New Zealand completes the Recertification Programme

Occupational therapists new to practice in Aotearoa New Zealand – which includes overseas-qualified registrants – complete the Board's Recertification Programme when they first practise here. For overseas-qualified practitioners that means fortnightly supervision and completion of Te Rito. It is not a mark against you. Its express intent is to ensure you begin practice with sufficient support, for your benefit and the protection of the public, and to give the Board assurance of competence before you practise independently. Trans-Tasman registrants are not required to participate. Factor supervision arrangements into your first year's planning and your choice of employer.

SECTION 09

Applying, and what happens next

1

Confirm your pathway

Standard overseas, abridged, or Trans-Tasman. Section 02.

2

Gather your documents

Certified qualification, transcript (and syllabus on the standard pathway), ID, certificates of good standing, criminal-history checks, and English results if required.

3

Submit your initial application and fee

Through the applicant portal, MyOTBNZ.

4

Complete the portal steps

Desktop competence self-assessment, nominate your referees, upload your CV, and begin Ngā Paerewa Te Tiriti when the Board opens it to you. Your application is not processed until these are provided.

5

Send hard copies

Post or courier the documents the Board requires in physical form.

6

Assessment and registration

Board-appointed occupational therapists assess your application. Once registered, apply for your practising certificate before you can work – you can apply for it at the same time as registration through the portal.

How long it takes, and what it costs

The Board publishes an indicative processing time that runs from the point all information, payment and printed documents have been received – so the bigger variable is usually how quickly you assemble complete, correctly certified evidence, not the Board's own processing. Fees are payable and non-refundable: the overseas registration fee, then the practising certificate, plus criminal-history checks and any primary source verification paid to the relevant providers.

Amounts and timings are deliberately not printed here. The Board publishes both on its website and revises them; confirm the current figures before you budget or pay.

— WHERE PEOPLE GET STUCK

Almost every avoidable delay traces back to one of these

A thin competence self-assessment

The biggest one. General statements instead of specific, evidenced examples mapped to each competency.

The wrong pathway

Standard when you qualify for abridged, or the reverse. Confirm your pathway first.

No suitable OT referee

Missing the occupational therapist who has worked with you for six months or more in the last two years.

Certification slips

Uncertified copies, missing translations, or forgetting that several documents must also go by post.

English results expired

Below the threshold in one component, or results older than twenty-four months at submission.

The fix for all of these

Confirm your pathway, draft the self-assessment early, line up the right referees, and have everything read by someone else before you submit.

SECTION 11

The questions we are asked most

Is there a faster route for UK-trained occupational therapists?+

Do I need IELTS, or will OET do?+

What is the desktop competence self-assessment?+

I'm registered in Australia — does that help?+

What is the Recertification Programme?+

Can Ethicare review my application?+

SECTION 12

The whole journey on one page

From first decision to first day at work. Each stage links to the section that explains it.

Before you start

Confirm your pathway

Standard, abridged or Trans-Tasman. [Section 02](#)

Start today

Draft your competence self-assessment

Map your practice to the Board's competencies. [Section 04](#)

Preparing

Gather qualification, identity and good-standing evidence

Certified, translated where needed. [Section 05](#)

Preparing

Line up three referees and your criminal-history checks

One referee an occupational therapist, six months in the last two years. [Section 06](#)

Preparing

Sit OET or IELTS, if required

Valid at submission. [Section 07](#)

Applying

Submit via MyOTBNZ, then complete the portal steps

Self-assessment, referees, CV. [Section 09](#)

Applying

Send hard copies; begin Ngā Paerewa when invited

[Section 08](#)

Assessment

Board-appointed occupational therapists assess your file

Respond promptly to any query.

Decision

Registration and practising certificate

Apply for both through the portal.

Then

Recertification Programme, employment and the move

Fortnightly supervision and Te Rito in your first period of practice; where registration hands over to [planning your move](#).

— THE CHECKLIST

Thirty-three items, in the order you will meet them

Tick as you go. Ticks are saved on this device only – nothing is sent to us – and the list is always the current version, which a downloaded copy never is.

0 of 33 ticked

[Clear all ticks](#)

01 Before you start

Get oriented and pick the right pathway before you spend money or gather documents.

☐ **Confirm which pathway applies to you** Standard overseas, abridged (UK, Ireland, Canada, South Africa) or Trans-Tasman (Ahpra).

☐ **If abridged: confirm your programme is WFOT-accredited** Required for the abridged route.

☐ **Confirm you are currently registered where you trained or practise** And that you can obtain a certificate of good standing.

☐ **Check whether you need an English test** Only if English is not your first language and you do not meet a recognised-country route.

☐ **Note that fees are payable and non-refundable** Confirm the current figures on the Board's fees page before budgeting.

02 Competence self-assessment — start early

The written desktop assessment is the centrepiece of an overseas application.

- ☐ **Download the Board's Competencies for Registration and Continuing Practice** Map your experience to each competency before you submit.
- ☐ **Draft specific, evidenced examples per competency** General statements rarely satisfy the assessors. We can read a draft.
- ☐ **Line up your OT referee to confirm it** On the standard pathway they review and confirm your self-assessment.
- ☐ **Note it is completed in the applicant portal** After your initial application; your file is not processed until it is done.

03 Qualifications

What the Board's appointed occupational therapists assess.

- ☐ **Certified occupational therapy qualification certificate** Original or certified copy.
- ☐ **Certified academic transcript** Original or certified copy.
- ☐ **Detailed course description or syllabus — standard pathway** Not required on the abridged pathway.
- ☐ **Be ready for primary source verification** The Board may require it, at your own cost.

04 Identity and references

Confirming who you are and that you are fit and proper.

- ☐ **Two certified forms of ID, one with a photo** Plus certified evidence of any name change.
- ☐ **Certified translations of any non-English documents** Alongside a certified copy in the original language.
- ☐ **Three referees lined up** Over 18, known you twelve months or more, not a relative, not at your address, and a person of good standing in the community.
- ☐ **At least one referee is an occupational therapist** Worked with you six months or more in the last two years.

05 Criminal history

Police checks with precise rules.

- ☐ **Criminal-conviction check for your country of registration** Plus any country lived in for six months or more in the last ten years.
- ☐ **Let the Board arrange the New Zealand check** Emailed to you during processing, unless you have never been to New Zealand.
- ☐ **Explanatory note if you have any conviction** Not an automatic bar — disclose fully.

06 English language — if required

Only if English is not your first language and you do not meet a recognised-country route.

- ☐ **Sit OET (occupational therapy version) or IELTS Academic** Meet the Board's threshold in every component.
- ☐ **Achieve the standard within twelve months if combining sittings** You may club results across sittings.
- ☐ **Results no older than twenty-four months at submission** Time the test so it stays valid.

07 Cultural competence

Required of every applicant — on the Board's cue.

- ☐ **Note Ngā Paerewa Te Tiriti is required** Approved online course via Ko Awatea LEARN.

☐ **Request your Ko Awatea account at the right time** Only after the Board updates your application number to a registration number.

☐ **Read about te Tiriti o Waitangi and Māori health** Worth doing now, ahead of the course.

08 Submit, and after

Putting it together and what follows.

☐ **Submit your initial application and fee via MyOTBNZ** The applicant portal.

☐ **Complete the portal steps: self-assessment, referees, CV** Your application is not processed until these are in.

☐ **Post or courier the hard-copy documents** Several must be supplied physically, not just uploaded.

☐ **Respond promptly to any Board queries** Speed of response is the biggest factor within your control.

☐ **Registration confirmed**

☐ **Apply for your practising certificate** Before you can work – it can be applied for alongside registration.

☐ **Begin the Recertification Programme** Fortnightly supervision and Te Rito for overseas-qualified registrants.

Print or save as PDF

WHAT NEXT?

Registration is one part of the decision

Check my pathway Your profession, where you trained, what you hold – and the route most likely to apply to you.

How registration works in New Zealand For every profession – the boards, the sequence, English and timelines.

Allied health in New Zealand The family of professions, and the pages for each.

Occupational therapist What the work is like, indicative pay, where you could live.

Plan your move Registration, visas, family and the order to do it in – personalised, saved in your browser.

HOW WE HELP

We can read it before the Board does

We review your evidence – particularly the competence self-assessment and your pathway choice – against what the Board looks for, and flag likely issues while they are still easy to fix. We support and guide you through the process; the registration decision always rests with the Occupational Therapy Board of New Zealand.

[Talk to Ethicare](#)

[The Board's own site](#) ↗